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CAPITAL ADVISORY

FOUNDER RESOURCE

Data Room Guide

How to structure a lender- and investor-ready data room that reduces friction
and accelerates diligence.

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A data room is not a document dump; it is the operational proof of the claims in your narrative.

Investors form a view of management quality from the data room long before they form a view of the business, because the room shows how the company keeps its own records. This guide covers structure, sequencing, and the operating discipline that keeps diligence moving.

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Structure

- Numbered folders aligned to diligence workstreams, so investor request lists map one-to-one onto your structure.
- An index document at the root with one-line descriptions of every folder and a change log.
- Consistent file naming: date, document type, and entity, in that order.
- Version control with superseded documents archived, never deleted; auditors and counsel will ask what changed.
- Access permissions tiered by process stage: teaser-stage visitors do not need employment agreements.

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Core Folders

- 01 Corporate and legal: formation documents, cap table, board minutes, and material contracts flagged for change-of-control provisions.
- 02 Financial statements and KPIs: audited statements, monthly management accounts, and the KPI definitions document that keeps every metric consistent.
- 03 Commercial and customers: customer contracts, concentration analysis, cohort data, and

pipeline reporting.

- 04 Operations and HR: organization chart, key employment agreements, and option grant reconciliation.
- 05 Tax and regulatory: structure chart, filings, open items, and licenses.

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Sequencing: Build in Investor-Priority Order

Populate the room in the order investors will read it, not the order documents are easiest to gather.

Cohort economics and monthly P&L reconciled to budget come first; they answer the first investment-committee question. Corporate housekeeping matters, but it convinces no one to invest; it only prevents them from closing.

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Q&A Operating Discipline

- Route every question through a single intake channel with an internal owner; parallel side-channels create inconsistent answers.
- Hold a forty-eight-hour response standard, and communicate proactively when an answer needs longer.
- Maintain a living FAQ so the tenth investor gets the same answer as the first, in the same words.
- Log which folders each party opens; access patterns tell you who is doing real work before their next call tells you.

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Best Practices

- Upload complete, executed documents; placeholders and unsigned versions read as unfinished housekeeping.
- Redact what is genuinely sensitive, but excessive blackouts invite more questions than they close.
- Refresh monthly financials on a fixed calendar day so investors learn the rhythm.
- Run a pre-launch audit against this guide with someone who did not build the room; the builder cannot see the gaps.

NEXT STEP

Put this to work with our team

This resource is part of the Keningford Partners founder toolkit. If you are preparing for a capital raise, sale process, or board decision, our team will review your materials against this framework and tell you where the gaps are, at no cost.

EMAIL

info@keningfordpartners.com

PHONE

+1 (315) 932-6269

OFFICE

136 Madison Ave, 7th Floor, New York, NY 10016, USA

WEB

keningfordpartners.com

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